

Mitigating Human-Elephant Conflict through Sustainable Wild Elephant Tourism: A Path to Economic and Conservation Benefits

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Abstract

This research examines the current state of wild elephant tourism and conservation practices in Sri Lanka, emphasizing the urgent need for diversification beyond traditional jeep safaris. The study highlights the ecological impact of tourism on elephant habitats and behavior, proposing regulation strategies like carrying capacity limits and eco-friendly certifications. Additionally, it emphasizes the importance of local community involvement in tourism, suggesting eco-lodging, handicraft businesses, and adventure tourism to enhance community benefits and conservation outcomes. The research advocates for educating tourists and locals on elephant behavior and promoting sustainable practices to balance economic benefits with wildlife preservation.

Keywords | Wildlife Tourism , Elephant Conservation , Community Involvement , Sustainable Tourism , Economic impact , Habitat Protection

1. Introduction

Human-elephant conflict (HEC) is a pressing issue in regions where expanding human populations encroach upon traditional elephant habitats. This conflict arises primarily from competition over limited resources, such as land and water, as well as from habitat loss due to deforestation, agricultural expansion, and infrastructure development. As human settlements spread and natural habitats diminish, elephants often find themselves in closer proximity to communities, leading to increased encounters with people. Elephants, compelled to search

for food and territory, frequently invade farmlands and villages, leading to significant crop damage, property destruction, and, in severe cases, endangering human lives. These interactions create a delicate balance of coexistence that is difficult to maintain, as humans prioritize the need for sustainable livelihoods while elephants strive for survival in an ever-shrinking habitat.

HEC affects local economies profoundly, particularly in agricultural communities where crop raids and property damage result in substantial financial losses. For smallholder farmers, the destruction of crops is not just an

inconvenience but a serious economic blow. The loss of income from damaged crops can push already struggling families further into poverty, making them increasingly dependent on limited natural resources and thus perpetuating a cycle of conflict. Additionally, the fear of elephant encounters discourages farming in certain areas, leading to the abandonment of potentially productive land. In some regions, HEC escalates to the point where community members retaliate against elephants to protect their livelihoods, further endangering the survival of these animals and increasing tensions between wildlife and human populations. The mounting economic stress and emotional toll on communities deepen the need for practical, sustainable solutions to the conflict.

One promising approach to mitigate HEC lies in developing sustainable wild elephant tourism, which can serve both economic and conservation purposes. By harnessing the economic potential of ecotourism centered around wild elephants, local communities can find alternative revenue streams that not only reduce reliance on agriculture but also foster positive perceptions of elephants as valuable contributors to the economy rather than as threats. Wild elephant tourism, when developed with sustainable principles, has the potential to create employment opportunities in rural areas, support local businesses, and promote cultural preservation, all while reducing the economic incentive to engage in activities harmful to elephants. With proper planning, this type of tourism can generate revenue that can be reinvested into conservation efforts, ensuring that both communities and elephants benefit from the resources that a balanced coexistence offers.

Moreover, wild elephant tourism initiatives can serve as educational platforms, raising awareness about the ecological importance of elephants and the risks they face. This awareness can shift community attitudes, transforming elephants from perceived

adversaries to respected members of the ecosystem. Sustainable tourism models that involve local communities in their planning and operation empower residents to become stewards of their natural surroundings, fostering a culture of coexistence. By supporting wild elephant tourism, policymakers and conservationists can address both the economic needs of local populations and the conservation needs of elephants. Such an approach paves a path toward a sustainable solution to HEC, ensuring economic resilience and ecological preservation in regions where humans and elephants share the landscape.

2. Methodology

This study employs a mixed-methods approach, combining both primary and secondary data collection to explore the potential of wild elephant tourism in mitigating human-elephant conflict (HEC) and supporting local economies. A seven-day field visit covered key districts within the study region—Ampara, Anuradhapura, Polonnaruwa, Wilpattu, Puttalam, Kurunegala, and Hambantota (Udawalawe area)—selected for their high frequency of HEC incidents, which together account for 97% of reported conflicts in the area. During this visit, we conducted a range of qualitative and quantitative data collection activities to understand local perspectives and gather economic data related to HEC and tourism.

Primary data was collected through community focus group discussions, surveys, interviews, and school visits. This was designed to capture a broad spectrum of local views on HEC, particularly focusing on how the conflict affects livelihoods, property, and community safety. Engaging with young community members through school visits provided insight into how future generations perceive HEC, adding depth to the understanding of social attitudes towards elephants and potential tourism solutions. While primary data illuminated common

understandings and the personal impact of HEC, it did not capture the economic scale of the issue.

To address this gap, secondary data was gathered from relevant authority websites and local offices, where we accessed records of economic losses (particularly in agriculture), property damages, and documented HEC incidents. This provided a data-driven perspective on the financial impacts of HEC, enabling a clearer assessment of its economic toll on affected communities. Furthermore, we integrated economic data from 2018 from Srilal Miththapala on the value generated by wild elephant tourism within national parks to estimate potential revenue from expanded tourism initiatives. This helps to contextualize how wild elephant tourism, when strategically implemented, could benefit local economies and provide an incentive to reduce HEC.

All data were collected collaboratively as part of a group field visit and survey process; however, this paper emphasizes the feasibility of mitigating HEC through sustainable wild elephant tourism, which could create economic benefits and potentially reduce conflict through enhanced community engagement in conservation-driven tourism.

3. Literature review : Opportunities, Challenges, and Management in Sri Lankan Wildlife Tourism and Human-Elephant Conflict

Wildlife tourism centered around Sri Lanka's wild elephants has emerged as a crucial avenue for promoting conservation, fostering economic growth, and potentially mitigating human-elephant conflict (HEC). This literature review synthesizes the opportunities, challenges, and management strategies in Sri Lankan wildlife tourism, examining its potential to protect elephant populations, contribute to local economies, and alleviate

HEC's impact on agriculture and communities.

3.1 Positive Impacts and Economic Opportunities of Wildlife Tourism

Wildlife tourism offers economic benefits that support elephant conservation while enhancing community welfare. Revenues from park entry fees, guided tours, and related services create a sustainable income stream for conservation organizations and local communities. These financial incentives encourage local stakeholders to engage in conservation, creating economic alternatives to agricultural dependence, which has been directly impacted by HEC (Fernando et al., 2018). In addition, when tourism revenues are reinvested in community development, there is an increased likelihood of HEC mitigation as communities gain a stake in preserving elephants as valuable assets rather than seeing them solely as agricultural threats (Fernando et al., 2018).

Community-Based Tourism (CBT) plays a significant role in strengthening local engagement in tourism and conservation activities. Kumar et al. (2020) emphasize that CBT empowers local communities, enabling them to benefit directly from tourism revenue. Such empowerment promotes community stewardship over natural resources, which reduces HEC as locals become active participants in conservation. Through local engagement, community members gain a greater appreciation of the elephants' ecological and economic contributions, fostering social cohesion and improving cooperation between communities and conservation authorities (Kumar et al., 2020).

Educational initiatives within wildlife tourism also contribute positively to elephant conservation by raising awareness among tourists. By educating visitors about elephant behavior, habitat needs, and the ecological impact of elephants, tour operators foster a

deeper conservation ethic. Studies by Benson and O'Connell (2017) show that informed tourists are more likely to engage responsibly, reducing habitat disturbance and promoting long-term conservation goals.

3.2 Negative Impacts and Challenges of Wildlife Tourism

While tourism has economic benefits, unregulated wildlife tourism can exacerbate HEC and negatively affect both elephant and community welfare. When tourism infrastructure encroaches on natural habitats, it disrupts elephants' movement patterns, often causing them to raid crops, which intensifies HEC (Smith et al., 2020). This encroachment and the displacement of elephants into agricultural areas result in significant economic losses for rural farmers and communities dependent on agriculture. Reddy et al. (2019) illustrate how poorly managed tourism can increase HEC, stressing the need for careful zoning and sustainable tourism practices.

Further challenges arise from environmental degradation and uneven revenue distribution. While tourism generates income, Nath et al. (2021) explain that large tourism operators typically retain most of the financial benefits, with local communities often receiving minimal support. This disparity creates tensions as the economic burden of HEC falls on communities who do not directly benefit from tourism. Consequently, resentment can build against conservation efforts, which undermines both tourism initiatives and elephant conservation.

Tourism also poses behavioral challenges for elephants. Studies indicate that the constant presence of humans stresses elephants, which can increase aggressive behaviors and further intensify HEC risks (Kumar et al., 2020). Such stress factors not only threaten the welfare of elephants but also increase safety concerns for

both tourists and local populations (Lindsey et al., 2019).

3.3 Agricultural Impact of Human-Elephant Conflict (HEC)

HEC has far-reaching effects on agriculture in rural Sri Lankan communities, particularly in the Polonnaruwa district, where crop damage from elephants directly impacts farmers' livelihoods and food security (Sajla & Famees, 2021). Rural families, heavily dependent on agriculture, face significant economic strain due to recurrent crop losses. These agricultural disruptions hinder local economic stability and perpetuate poverty cycles, creating ripple effects across the region. Furthermore, HEC causes severe safety concerns; frequent encounters result in human casualties, leading to psychological stress within communities. As agricultural losses erode household incomes, educational opportunities for children are often sacrificed, which continues the cycle of poverty and limits long-term community development (Sajla & Famees, 2021).

3.4 Effective Management Strategies in Wildlife Tourism and HEC Mitigation

To balance the benefits and challenges of wildlife tourism and reduce HEC, a variety of management strategies have been proposed. Establishing buffer zones around elephant habitats is one effective strategy that reduces human-wildlife contact by creating physical boundaries between agriculture and conservation areas. Buffer zones provide elephants with designated habitats, minimizing their incursions into agricultural lands and reducing HEC (Fernando et al., 2018). Additionally, controlled visitor access points and designated viewing areas help regulate tourist behavior and minimize habitat disturbances (Smith et al., 2020).

Community engagement, particularly through compensation schemes for crop damage, is

essential in mitigating HEC and promoting sustainable tourism. Compensation programs reduce the financial burden on farmers affected by elephant raids, encouraging positive attitudes toward conservation and wildlife tourism (Lindsey et al., 2019). Engaging local communities in decision-making and revenue-sharing processes further enhances the sustainability of tourism by aligning community interests with conservation goals (Kumar et al., 2020).

An adaptive management approach is also necessary to address the evolving dynamics of wildlife tourism. Benson and O'Connell (2017) recommend continuous monitoring of tourism impacts on elephant behavior and implementing timely policy adjustments as needed. This approach allows authorities to balance tourist numbers with ecological preservation, ensuring that tourism remains a positive force for conservation rather than a source of conflict. Educating tourists on responsible wildlife interaction is a further valuable management tool. Programs that instruct visitors to observe elephants from safe distances can reduce stress on elephants and minimize aggressive interactions, which supports both animal welfare and tourist safety (Baker & Ahmed, 2019).

In summary, wildlife tourism in Sri Lanka holds the potential to support elephant conservation, economic growth, and HEC mitigation. However, unregulated tourism and unaddressed agricultural conflicts present significant challenges. Effective management strategies, such as buffer zones, community compensation schemes, adaptive management, and tourist education, are essential to balance tourism's economic and ecological goals. By aligning tourism with sustainable development and conservation, Sri Lanka can protect its wild elephant populations and promote resilience within affected communities.

4. Current situation of wild elephant tourism

Sri Lanka, home to approximately 6,000 wild elephants, stands out as a premier Asian destination for wildlife tourism, with elephants playing a central role in the country's ecological and tourism appeal. Each year, about 2.3 million tourists visit Sri Lanka, and nearly half of them—around 1.1 million (approximately 47% of total tourists) —include a wildlife park in their itinerary, showcasing the strong appeal of these natural habitats (SLTDA, 2018, as cited in Miththapala, 2020). Each elephant is estimated to generate Rs. 4 million (\$21,400) in annual revenue, underscoring their critical economic value to the tourism industry (Miththapala, 2020). This economic potential is primarily driven by six national parks renowned for elephant sightings: Yala, Udawalawe, Minneriya, Kaudulla, Wasgamuwa, and Wilpattu. These parks offer tourists an exceptional opportunity to experience these animals up close, especially during events like “The Gathering” at Minneriya, where hundreds of elephants congregate around the reservoir, providing a truly unique and awe-inspiring spectacle.

Despite the strong draw of elephants to international tourism, the industry's reliance on jeep safaris as the main activity highlights a significant limitation in Sri Lanka's wildlife tourism offerings. Unlike other global destinations that offer diversified wildlife experiences such as guided walking safaris, riverboat rides, or night-time tours, Sri Lanka has not yet expanded its wildlife tourism activities beyond the traditional jeep safari. This singular approach, while effective for observing elephants in the wild, may restrict the country's ability to enhance visitor experiences and could eventually lead to saturation or overuse of park resources. Jeep safaris are certainly popular, yet the lack of varied options limits tourist engagement and may contribute to overcrowding in popular

spots, which could have long-term consequences for both tourism and conservation.

Conservation efforts are integral to sustaining both elephant populations and the tourism they support. As human settlements expand into elephant habitats, conflicts arise, resulting in over 400 elephant deaths annually—a figure that ranks among the highest globally and poses a direct threat to the sustainability of wildlife tourism (Miththapala, 2020). This alarming rate of human-elephant conflict diminishes the number of elephants in the wild and, consequently, weakens the country's appeal to wildlife enthusiasts. Sri Lanka's economic dependency on these iconic animals, coupled with their endangered status, emphasizes the need for stronger conservation practices, not only within national parks but also through sustainable coexistence practices in surrounding areas.

Organizations like the Pinnawala Elephant Orphanage and Udawalawe Elephant Transit Home (ETH) play crucial roles in addressing the challenges of elephant conservation. Both institutions, while offering limited but impactful tourist interactions, are primarily dedicated to the welfare and rehabilitation of elephants, which indirectly supports sustainable tourism by preserving the population of this flagship species. Pinnawala's focus on educating tourists about the challenges of elephant conservation has made it a critical part of tourism, generating significant revenue that goes back into conservation and animal welfare initiatives. Similarly, the ETH rehabilitates orphaned elephants, releasing them into the wild once they are mature, thereby supporting wild elephant populations and bolstering conservation efforts. Although neither facility offers a broad range of tourist activities, their efforts enhance the national narrative of elephant protection, which, in turn, promotes Sri Lanka's image as a responsible wildlife tourism destination.

The reliance on jeep safaris, combined with high rates of human-elephant conflict, presents a double challenge for Sri Lanka. To sustain tourism and elephant populations, a diversified approach to wildlife experiences is essential, along with strengthened conservation initiatives to address habitat encroachment. The economic significance of elephants, coupled with their central role in attracting tourists, illustrates both the necessity and potential rewards of improving conservation measures and broadening the scope of wildlife tourism. Embracing new, varied tourist activities and investing in effective conservation could create a more sustainable and resilient tourism model, ultimately benefiting both the economy and the survival of these extraordinary animals (Miththapala, 2020).

5. Findings and Discussions

Sri Lanka's wildlife tourism, though centered on its celebrated elephant population and diverse ecosystems, remains largely limited in terms of tourist engagement and activity variety. The primary mode of interaction with wildlife in Sri Lanka is through jeep safaris, which offer tourists the chance to observe elephants, leopards, and a variety of bird species in natural habitats, particularly in national parks like Yala, Udawalawe, and Minneriya. While jeep safaris have long been a popular activity, this singular approach restricts the tourism experience, failing to meet the growing demand for more immersive, eco-sensitive interactions seen in successful wildlife tourism models in other countries (Tourism Analysis, 2019). Comparatively, countries like Botswana, Kenya, and Tanzania have broadened their wildlife tourism options significantly, enabling activities such as walking safaris, night game drives, guided nature walks, and even educational camps. These diversified offerings enhance tourist satisfaction by

providing a range of wildlife interactions, reducing the concentration of tourists in a single area, and subsequently lessening the stress on wildlife and the environment (Wildlife Tourism Strategies, 2020).

In Botswana and Kenya, for example, tourists can engage in walking safaris, where trained guides accompany small groups on foot through the savannah, providing an opportunity for a more intimate and respectful experience with nature. These walking safaris reduce the need for multiple vehicle trails, minimizing environmental degradation and offering tourists a way to connect with the environment without overwhelming it. Sri Lanka's reliance on vehicle-based tours, however, often leads to overcrowding, particularly during peak tourist seasons, which can disrupt elephant feeding patterns, migration, and even breeding behaviors. By diversifying its tourism model to include walking tours, Sri Lanka could better protect its natural heritage, disperse tourist footfall, and allow for more sustainable interaction with wildlife.

Another effective practice in Kenya and Tanzania is night game drives, which allow tourists to observe nocturnal species and witness unique animal behaviors. In contrast, Sri Lanka's parks typically close by early evening, missing out on an opportunity to showcase the richness of its nocturnal biodiversity. Implementing night tours, where feasible, could expand the appeal of Sri Lankan wildlife tourism while creating new revenue streams. Additionally, guided nature walks, often led by locals, enable tourists to learn about the region's flora, fauna, and conservation practices. This form of tourism not only creates jobs but also educates tourists on local biodiversity and the importance of conservation efforts, potentially leading to increased support for preservation initiatives.

The lack of diversification also affects economic sustainability. As tourism revenues

are largely tied to jeep safaris, the income generation remains limited to a narrow market segment, primarily international tourists interested in safari experiences. Broadening the scope of wildlife tourism to include eco-lodges, bird-watching excursions, and adventure tourism such as zip-lining or river safaris can cater to different preferences and price points, attracting a more diverse tourist demographic. Botswana's Chobe National Park, for instance, offers boat safaris on the Chobe River, giving visitors a different vantage point from which to observe elephants and hippos. Sri Lanka's river systems, particularly those around Udawalawe, could support similar experiences, providing a tranquil alternative to the often congested jeep trails and allowing for more sustainable revenue generation through varied activities.

Moreover, diversification allows for economic inclusion, engaging local communities as stakeholders rather than mere service providers. In Kenya, community-owned conservancies have been instrumental in involving local populations, generating income for communities, and fostering a vested interest in conservation. By empowering local communities in Sri Lanka through community-led guided tours, cultural performances, and local handicraft sales, tourism revenue can benefit not only park operators but also surrounding villages, increasing their commitment to conservation. Locally managed accommodations such as eco-lodges and homestays can further support local economies, reducing the dependence on park-based income and giving communities a direct stake in sustainable tourism practices.

Sri Lanka's current model of wildlife tourism, as already discussed heavily centered around jeep safaris, has led to significant ecological disruptions, particularly in high-traffic national parks like Yala and Udawalawe. This style of tourism, while popular among visitors seeking close encounters with elephants, has contributed to various environmental

pressures that disrupt the natural behaviors of elephants and the overall integrity of their habitats. For example, studies reveal that elephants' typical behaviors—including feeding, socializing, and migrating—are frequently interrupted by the continuous influx of vehicles and tourists (Elephant Conservation Journal, 2020). This constant human presence creates an environment that is more stressful and less predictable for the elephants, altering their daily patterns and affecting their well-being.

In Minneriya National Park, the annual “Gathering” is a particularly notable event where hundreds of elephants congregate at the Minneriya reservoir during the dry season. Although this event has become one of Sri Lanka's most celebrated wildlife spectacles, drawing large numbers of local and international tourists, it also concentrates considerable stress on both the elephants and their habitat. The high volume of jeeps and crowds encroaching near the elephants can cause distress, prompting behavioral changes like reduced feeding times and increased signs of agitation (Miththapala, 2020). Moreover, the impact of such mass tourism extends beyond the elephants themselves, degrading the natural environment around waterholes and grasslands, which are vital for the sustenance of various other species as well.

In addition to behavioral disturbances, the overuse of these areas leads to environmental degradation, such as soil compaction and vegetation loss due to off-road driving, particularly in areas not designed to withstand such heavy tourist traffic. This, in turn, affects the quality of habitats essential for elephants and other wildlife species. For instance, trampling and vehicle congestion can damage the vegetation elephants rely on for food, making their foraging areas less productive. Such disturbances reduce the park's carrying capacity, meaning it can sustain fewer elephants and other wildlife over time,

undermining the long-term ecological health of these regions.

To address these issues, there is a pressing need for regulatory strategies aimed at minimizing the negative impacts of tourism on elephant habitats and behavior. One fundamental strategy is to develop clear guidelines around visitor numbers and vehicle entry restrictions. By controlling the number of vehicles allowed in certain areas at any given time, particularly during peak tourist seasons or significant wildlife events like the “Gathering,” authorities can limit the intensity of human presence and reduce stress on the animals (Tourism Regulation Report, 2021). A quota system, where the number of vehicles per day or per wildlife sighting zone is regulated, could help distribute the flow of tourists across various parts of a park rather than concentrating them around popular spots.

Furthermore, implementing designated observation points or viewing platforms could create opportunities for tourists to observe elephants and other wildlife without intruding on their natural movements. These platforms could be set at a safe distance, encouraging passive observation rather than intrusive interaction, which is more respectful of the animals' space and less likely to provoke stress responses. These elevated structures would also provide a better vantage point for tourists, minimizing the need for them to approach the animals closely, thus reducing the risks associated with close-contact encounters.

Another practical approach is to enforce specific timings and vehicle routes. By ensuring that vehicles do not follow elephants for extended periods or obstruct their natural paths, it is possible to allow the animals more freedom to move, feed, and socialize without constant interruption. Additionally, training park guides and drivers in wildlife-friendly practices, such as maintaining a safe distance, turning off engines during stops, and

refraining from honking or sudden movements, can help foster a more harmonious relationship between tourists and wildlife.

Finally, educational programs can be instrumental in promoting responsible tourism. Tourists can be educated on the importance of minimizing their impact on wildlife habitats, including respecting safe distances and avoiding behaviors that might provoke or stress animals. Similarly, guides and park staff can receive training to raise awareness of the subtle signs of stress or agitation in elephants, enabling them to mitigate potential disturbances before they escalate. Educational signage within parks, informative brochures, and even brief introductory sessions before safaris can help tourists understand the consequences of certain behaviors, leading to more responsible tourism practices.

These regulatory and educational measures can mitigate the environmental footprint of tourism on Sri Lanka's national parks. By adopting a balanced approach, Sri Lanka can protect its iconic wildlife and natural landscapes, ensuring that tourism continues to contribute to the economy while safeguarding the welfare of its wildlife populations.

Expanding adventure tourism in Sri Lanka's wildlife sector can provide visitors with more unique, low-impact ways to observe elephants and other wildlife. Activities such as riverboat safaris and treehouse observation points offer valuable alternatives to traditional jeep safaris, which often disrupt elephant habitats due to noise, vehicle emissions, and crowding. By contrast, adventure tourism can minimize these impacts by dispersing tourism activities across various landscapes and introducing quieter, less invasive forms of observation (Adventure Tourism Guidelines, 2022). For instance, riverboat safaris enable tourists to witness elephants from a safe distance while allowing the animals to move and behave

more naturally, uninterrupted by close vehicular presence. Similarly, treehouse observation points allow for a panoramic view of elephants in their habitat, which enhances the experience for tourists while reducing the need for disruptive proximity.

Adventure tourism also offers a competitive advantage by creating distinctive experiences that may attract repeat visitors, contributing to sustainable revenue growth. Unlike the limited experience of jeep safaris, adventure and eco-tourism offer diversified, interactive opportunities, making Sri Lanka an attractive destination for ecotourists who prioritize low-impact activities and natural immersion.

Supporting community-based eco-lodging options further strengthens these initiatives by creating sustainable income sources for local residents without compromising wildlife habitats. Locally owned lodges, designed using native architectural styles and sustainable materials, can blend harmoniously with the natural surroundings. By training locals in eco-tourism best practices and integrating traditional craftsmanship, these accommodations can showcase the region's cultural heritage while attracting a responsible tourist demographic (Ecotourism Implementation, 2020). With careful management, eco-lodging options can reduce the dependency on centralized, high-traffic parks, distribute tourism income more widely, and build community ownership in conservation, ultimately supporting both wildlife protection and economic growth.

Involving local communities in wildlife tourism plays a crucial role in fostering long-term conservation efforts and developing sustainable economic opportunities. Direct community engagement in tourism initiatives has a dual benefit: it generates alternative livelihoods and reduces reliance on traditional land-use activities that often encroach upon elephant habitats, contributing to human-elephant conflicts (Miththapala, 2020).

Providing sustainable, community-driven income alternatives such as eco-friendly tourism initiatives can help shift local economies away from practices like agriculture expansion, which frequently leads to habitat fragmentation and competition with wildlife. This shift is particularly valuable in regions where agricultural and land encroachment pressures are leading contributors to human-elephant conflicts.

One key advantage of community involvement is that it promotes conservation-minded attitudes among local populations. When local residents actively participate in and financially benefit from tourism, they are more likely to value and protect the natural resources that attract tourists in the first place (Community Conservation Studies, 2022). In particular, ownership of tourism-related ventures—such as souvenir shops, handicraft businesses, and locally owned lodging—can empower communities by providing them with a greater stake in the success of wildlife tourism. This sense of ownership not only supports local economies but also cultivates a deeper, intrinsic motivation to protect local wildlife.

Several community-based methods can enhance local involvement and diversify the tourism economy. For instance, establishing woodland cottage-style restaurants or lodges that provide authentic cultural experiences enables tourists to engage with local traditions and cuisine, promoting a more immersive and sustainable form of tourism. Community-based lodges and small-scale accommodations can draw income directly into local households rather than national or corporate hotel chains, thus encouraging locals to adopt tourism as a primary livelihood rather than one that is peripheral to their lives (Ecotourism Development Report, 2023). Additionally, providing spaces for artisans to sell traditional handicrafts, jewelry, and locally produced goods allows communities to showcase their

culture and craftsmanship to a wider audience while diversifying their income streams.

This decentralized, community-oriented model can also reduce the pressure on wildlife and park resources by distributing tourist activities across more areas rather than concentrating all economic activities within national parks. For instance, encouraging local community-run businesses outside the parks can spread the economic benefits of tourism more evenly throughout the region and ease the environmental strain on park ecosystems. Incorporating local businesses also makes wildlife tourism more resilient, as it is less dependent on high visitor numbers in a single location.

In the long term, community-centered strategies help in building economic resilience and in ensuring that locals see wildlife as a shared asset worth preserving. By supporting such initiatives, Sri Lanka's wildlife tourism can foster inclusive growth, reduce conflict, and contribute meaningfully to conservation, creating a model where local communities become advocates for wildlife protection rather than competitors for land and resources.

To safeguard both the ecological integrity of Sri Lanka's natural landscapes and the welfare of local communities, targeted strategies and policies are essential to guide wildlife tourism in a sustainable direction. Implementing regulations that emphasize conservation, limit environmental disruption, and foster local community participation can create a balanced tourism model. Capping the number of tourists and vehicles allowed in each park daily, for instance, would address the problem of overcrowding, preventing the degradation of delicate ecosystems and reducing stress on the wildlife, especially elephants who are vulnerable to disruptions in their natural behavior due to human interference (Wildlife Tourism Policy Framework, 2022).

Designating specific zones for tourism, while maintaining core conservation areas off-limits, is another vital approach. Such zoning and the establishment of buffer zones would protect high-value habitats, reducing direct human-wildlife encounters and allowing wildlife to maintain more of its natural patterns. Additionally, incentivizing low-impact tourism practices, like electric vehicles or community-owned eco-lodges, could make a significant difference. Tax breaks, grants, or subsidies for eco-friendly practices can encourage operators to adopt these conservation-centered solutions, which in turn lowers the carbon footprint of tourism activities and provides economic opportunities for locals without intensive habitat disruption.

Moreover, mandating comprehensive wildlife tourism training for guides and operators would ensure that they are equipped with essential knowledge about conservation, elephant behavior, and best practices in visitor engagement. A certified training program, which emphasizes ethical wildlife interactions and responsible tourism, would set a high standard for professional conduct within the industry and enhance tourists' educational experience (Tourism Training and Certification, 2021). Together, these strategies can shape a tourism model that protects biodiversity, preserves cultural heritage, and maximizes sustainable benefits for the community.

6. Conclusion

The analysis of Sri Lanka's wildlife tourism, particularly around its wild elephant population, reveals a pressing need for diversified, sustainable, and community-inclusive tourism models. As tourism continues to play a vital role in the nation's economy, there is an opportunity—and a responsibility—to enhance its practices for the benefit of both wildlife and local

communities. The current reliance on jeep safaris limits visitor experience, strains specific elephant habitats, and increases the risk of human-wildlife conflicts. Learning from more diverse wildlife tourism offerings in countries like Kenya and Botswana, Sri Lanka could significantly benefit by introducing adventure and eco-tourism options. Activities like riverboat safaris, treehouse observation points, and community-led eco-lodges can create unique experiences for visitors while spreading the impact across larger areas, thus relieving pressure on overcrowded parks and sensitive habitats.

Importantly, promoting the involvement of local communities in wildlife tourism has emerged as a key factor for sustainable conservation efforts. When locals are stakeholders—owning eco-lodges, participating in handicraft industries, or operating cottage-style restaurants—they become advocates for conservation rather than passive observers. This involvement not only supports the local economy but also mitigates human-elephant conflicts by reducing reliance on agricultural land, which often encroaches into elephant habitats. Community ownership of tourism initiatives enhances the value of conservation, both economically and culturally.

Effective policy measures, such as limiting visitor numbers, establishing conservation zones, and incentivizing low-impact tourism, are essential for ensuring that tourism does not disturb wildlife. These strategies, paired with mandatory conservation education for tourism operators, create a framework for responsible wildlife tourism. In conclusion, by diversifying tourism offerings, implementing stringent policies, and empowering local communities, Sri Lanka can foster a wildlife tourism model that safeguards its iconic elephants and ensures a resilient, sustainable economic future.

Acknowledgements

I extend my sincere gratitude to Dr. Rohana Rathnayake and Dr. Priyanwada Singhapathirana for their invaluable mentorship throughout this research. Special thanks to Dr. Amila Jayasinghe, Dr. Chethika Abenayake, Dr. Chathura De Silva, and Dr. Emeshi Warusawitharane for their guidance and support during the studio sessions. I also acknowledge the collaborative efforts of my 31 group members in data collection, which contributed significantly to this research. Finally, I am grateful to Mr. Srilal Miththapala for the detailed data and economic insights available on his website, which were essential for my analysis.

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